by Pakistan's National Assembly do not apply to the FATA unless so ordered by the President. According to the FATA Secretariat, "Interference in local matters is kept to a minimum."[31] Adult franchise was introduced in the FATA only in 1996, and political parties and civil society organizations are still restricted from operating there. Efforts are underway to rescind or reform the FCR, and the civilian government seated in Islamabad in 2008 has vowed to work to bring the FATA under the more effective writ of the state. The U.S. government supports Islamabad's "Frontier Strategy" of better integrating the FATA into the mainstream of Pakistan's political and economic system.[32] Many analysts insist that only through this course can the FATA's militancy problem be resolved.

U.S. POLICY

U.S. policy in the FATA seeks to combine better coordinated U.S. and Pakistani military efforts to neutralize militant threats in the short term with economic development initiatives meant to reduce extremism in Pakistan over the longer-term. Congressional analysts have identified serious shortcomings in the Bush Administration's FATA policy: In April 2008, the Government Accountability Office issued a report in response to congressional requests for an assessment of progress in meeting U.S. national security goals related to counterterrorism efforts in Pakistan's FATA. Their investigation found that, "The United States has not met its national security goals to destroy terrorist threats and close safe haven in Pakistan's FATA," and, "No comprehensive plan for meeting U.S. national security goals in the FATA has been developed." House Foreign Affairs Committee Chairman Representative Howard Berman called the conclusions "appalling."[33]

Increasing U.S.-Pakistan Cooperation and Coordination

In late 2008, U.S. officials have indicated that they are seeing greater Pakistani cooperation. In February 2008, Pakistan stopped attending meetings of the Tripartite Commission under which NATO, Afghan, and Pakistani forces meet regularly on both sides of the border. However, according to General McKiernan on November 18, 2008, the meetings resumed in June 2008 and three have been held since then, with another planned in December 2008. Gen. McKiernan, Pakistan's Chief of Staff Ashfaq Pervez Kayani, and Afghan Chief of Staff Bismillah Khan represent their respective forces in that commission. In April 2008, in an extension of the commission's work, the three forces agreed to set up five "border coordination centers" — which will include networks of radar nodes to give liaison officers a common view of the border area. These centers build on an agreement in May 2007 to share intelligence on extremists' movements. Only one has been established to date, at the Torkham border crossing. According to U.S. Army chief of staff Gen. George Casey in November 2008, cooperation is continuing to improve with meetings between U.S. and Pakistani commanders once a week. Also, U.S. commanders have praised October 2008 Pakistani military moves against militant enclaves in the tribal areas, and U.S. and Pakistani forces are jointly waging the "Operation Lionheart" offensive against militants on both sides of the border, north of the Khyber Pass.

Copyright © 2010. Nova Science Publishers, Incorporated. All rights reserved.

Combating Islamic Militancy and Terrorism in Pakistan's Border Region, Nova Science Publishers, Incorporated, 2010. ProQuest Ebook Central,